



◀ MOUNTED BOWMAN

In warfare and hunting, nomads used a short, powerful bow made from wood, horn, and sinew, fired from horseback. This felt hanging, from a Siberian kurgan, shows a horseman with a short bow case at his side.

Two Scythians fight a mounted Greek soldier.



▲ SCYTHIAN GOLD

The richest kurgans belonged to the tribe of the Scythians, who lived in what is now southern Siberia from around the 7th century BCE. This Greek gold comb was found in the tomb of a king, whose body was completely covered in gold items.

Steppe nomads

The steppes of Eurasia are a vast, dry, treeless plain, stretching from Europe to the borders of China. Although not suitable for farming, the land is good for grazing animals. For 5,500 years, the steppes have been the home of horse-riding nomads, people who are constantly on the move, searching for fresh pastures.

Early steppe nomads spent their lives on horseback, accompanying sheep, goats, camels, and cattle on great journeys. They used carts to carry their belongings, including the tents in which they slept each night. At the edges of the steppe, they would trade horses and animal products with settled peoples, who in turn provided them with metals and other goods. Steppe nomads buried their dead beneath mounds, each called a *kurgan*, often full of treasures acquired through trading and raiding.

In the first millennium BCE, nomadic tribes began to gather in huge mobile hordes, threatening settled civilizations. From the 5th century BCE, the Xiongnu of Mongolia regularly raided China. To meet the threat, in 215 BCE, China's first emperor, Qin Shi Huangdi, built a great wall across his northern frontier. Later, in the 1st century CE, the Kushans from Central Asia conquered Afghanistan and northwest India. They were followed, in the 4th and 5th centuries, by the Huns, whose empire stretched from western Asia into Europe.

ATTILA THE HUN

Attila ruled the Huns from 434–453 CE. During his reign, the Huns conquered lands from the Rhine in western Europe to the Caspian Sea in Central Asia. Western European empires came to fear Attila's plundering armies.



SOME LATER EUROPEAN DEPICTIONS OF ATTILA, SUCH AS THIS MEDALLION, SHOWED HIM WITH HORNS LIKE A DEVIL